

**BURKINA FASO**

Capital city: Ouagadougou
Area: 105,869 sq miles (274,200 sq km)
Population: 13,000,000
Official language: French
Major religions: Muslim 55%, traditional beliefs 35%, Christian 10%
Government: Multiparty democracy
Currency: CFA franc
Adult literacy rate: 25%
Life expectancy: 43 years
People per doctor: 33,333
Televisions: 9 per 1,000 people

TOGO

Capital city: Lomé
Area: 21,924 sq miles (56,785 sq km)
Population: 4,900,000
Official languages: French
Major religions: Traditional beliefs 50%, Christian 35%, Muslim 15%
Government: Multiparty democracy
Currency: CFA franc
Adult literacy rate: 60%
Life expectancy: 50 years
People per doctor: 10,000
Televisions: 18 per 1,000 people

BURKINA FASO

LANDLOCKED BURKINA FASO (formerly known as Upper Volta) is one of the world's poorest countries. Like the other countries in the Sahel region, Burkina Faso is at constant risk from drought, and in recent years large amounts of grazing land have turned to desert as the Sahara has expanded southward. Burkina Faso has few cities, and most of the people live in villages, making a living from farming and herding. Burkina Faso's economy has suffered badly from political unrest. Because the country is so poor, millions of people from Burkina Faso must go abroad to find jobs.



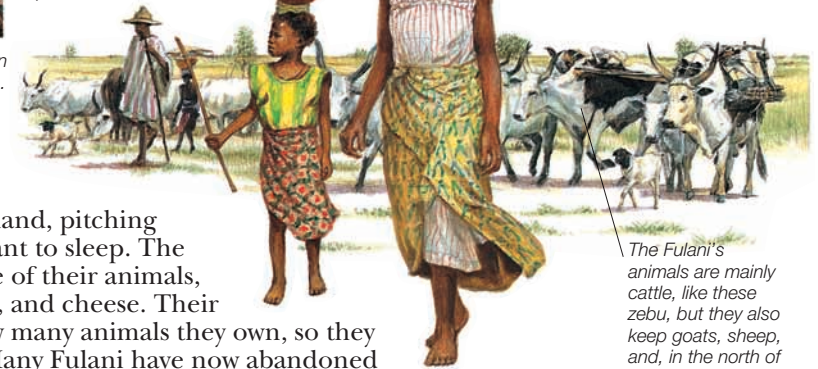
Many farmers have a vegetable garden where they grow food for their families.

AGRICULTURE

Lack of water and poor soil cause huge problems for Burkina Faso's farmers. Before any crops can be planted, a farmer has to clear the land, burning the scrub and plowing the ash into the ground to act as a fertilizer. The new field can only be used for four to five years before it is exhausted. Then it has to be left for at least another five years to recover.

THE FULANI

The Fulani are nomadic cattle herders. They travel wherever there is grazing land, pitching huts or tents when they want to sleep. The Fulani live off the produce of their animals, eating mainly milk, butter, and cheese. Their wealth is measured by how many animals they own, so they rarely kill and eat them. Many Fulani have now abandoned this nomadic way of life and have settled in one place.



The Fulani carry many of their possessions in large bowls called calabashes, which are made from the dried shells of gourds.

The calabash rests on a roll of cloth.

The Fulani's animals are mainly cattle, like these zebu, but they also keep goats, sheep, and, in the north of the region, camels.

**FOREIGN AID**

Burkina Faso is very dependent on foreign aid. Each year around US\$400 million of aid comes into the country, much of it from Burkina Faso's former colonial ruler, France, and from the European Union. The money is used for both large-scale projects, such as dams to generate hydroelectric power, and smaller programs, like this well that provides clean water for a village.

TOGO

SANDWICHED BETWEEN GHANA and Benin, Togo is a former French colony that gained its independence in 1960. The population is a mix of about 30 different ethnic groups; the two largest are the Ewe in the south of the country and the Dagomba in the north. Phosphates – minerals used to make fertilizers – account for half of Togo's exports, but the economy has been badly affected by changes in world phosphate prices. Togo's capital city, Lomé, is one of the major ports in West Africa.

**FARMING AND FISHING**

Although Togo is a very poor country, it produces nearly all its own food. About two-thirds of the population lives in the countryside and works there as farmers. Corn, yams, rice, and cassava are grown to eat, and cocoa, coffee, and cotton to sell and export. Along the coast, many people make a living from fishing.

Find out more

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